Court report

This report summarises the digital forensic examination carried out on devices linked with the suspect known as “Ms. Taurus Smith” in relation to the suspected theft of confidential Lard & Land recipe data. A forensic image of the suspect’s laptop was examined along with supplied PCAP network capture files and an NTUSER.DAT registry record. These were analysed using recognised forensic tools including Autopsy and Wireshark.

Recipe-related images and documents belonging to Lard & Land were found stored inside the user profile of Taurus Smith’s laptop. Some files were still present and accessible whilst several important files had been deleted from the computer. Although they were no longer visible to the user, forensic tools allowed them to be recovered. The deletion of recipe files and references to another person suggests an effort to hide or destroy evidence. The presence of these files in the “SendTo” folder suggests they may have been prepared for copying or transmitting to someone else. Furthermore, registry records confirmed that the suspect regularly opened Microsoft Excel and had accessed highly sensitive business spreadsheets.

We must also mention that software capable of hiding data (steganography tools) was also recovered from deleted space, suggesting that data-concealment techniques were available to the user. Alongside this, USB device history confirmed that external storage devices were connected to the laptop during the relevant period, providing a practical means of copying data off the system.

An email was found on the suspect’s computer which contained what appears to be encoded hidden data. The sender also told the recipient that the information needed to be “decoded”. This strongly suggests that the email was being used to secretly transfer confidential company information in a way that would not be immediately readable or easily detected. Internet browsing history recovered from the laptop shows that the user had been visiting shopping websites, weather websites and entertainment forums, as well as searching for computer forensic and communication software. These findings suggest the user was capable of handling and transferring digital information.

Network traffic captures showed that the suspect’s laptop communicated with both an internal device and an external server. The captured data included readable chat messages in which the suspect referred to downloading a “secret project file,” copying it to a USB drive and arranging to meet another person in Hawaii. This demonstrates deliberate communication and preparation to transfer data.

Once you piece the evidence together, the evidence indicates that confidential company information was accessed, handled, deleted and prepared for transfer to another party. This was then followed by communication to another party via emails and direct communication, which suggests intent to as supposed to accidental general traffic. There is strong evidence that at least one other person was involved in this activity. The evidence was handled safely and professionally at all times, following proper forensic procedures.